

sort creates its own toothpaste and lip balms, and guests are taught how to make them. “Sustainability is a lifestyle change and one that we need to encourage amongst our guests,” says Chakravarty.

GONE ARE THE days when luxury hospitality players gave lip service to sustainability, asking guests to reuse their towels. “We decided to take the road less travelled and bring luxury and sustainability together in a way that the guest experiences luxury and contributes to a planet-positive world,” says Anil Chadha, Divisional Chief Executive, ITC Hotels. And so it was that ITC Hotels became pioneers of the sustainability drive.

82 | Beginning at the design stage, steps are taken at all ITC hotels to ensure that energy, water and solid waste efficiencies are maximised. From optimising the use of natural light to meeting electrical demand through wind and solar energy; conserving water through rainwater harvesting; treating and recycling water; and attaining near-zero waste generation status by reducing, reusing and recycling the solid waste generated—every effort is made to preserve the ecosystem. While all ITC premium hotels are rated LEED Platinum—a rating awarded by the US Green Building Council—some, such as ITC Windsor and ITC Gardenia in Bengaluru and ITC Chola in Chennai, are zero-carbon properties.

“More than 57 per cent of our electrical energy is met through renewable sources, offsetting more than 50 million kg of CO₂ emissions annually,” says Chadha. ITC Hotels has reduced consider-

able consumption of freshwater over the past five years by treating all wastewater through on-site STPs and then using it for irrigation, flushing and cooling tower requirements. ITC found that luxury hotels generated 250,000 kg of single-use-plastic a year—including 15 million water bottles; these have since been replaced with Shunya, ITC’s in-house water brand which is the result of water purification and glass bottling plants at all its luxury hotels. “We got rid of all plastic toiletries across hotels in 45 days. Our survey showed that most business travellers carried their own toiletries,” says Chadha.

Travellers today are also more conscious. A global study of 9,000

adults commissioned by IHG Hotels & Resorts revealed that consumers are more mindful than ever about travelling responsibly, with 82 per cent saying it is important to choose a hotel brand that operates responsibly. The research found that consumers will spend, on average, 31 per cent more on accommodation that does this. And while those are global figures, a survey among Indian travellers by Booking.com revealed a similar sentiment. According to the 2022 Sustainable Travel Research Report, 91 per cent of Indian travellers say that they want to travel more sustainably over the coming 12 months—a 76 per cent increase over the company’s data last year.



(From left) The Oberoi Udaivilas in Udaipur sources up to 50 per cent of its energy from solar power. The Raffles Udaipur has ensured that the 21-acre island of the Udaipur Sagar Lake, Raffles Udaipur has ensured that the 21-acre island